Recognition and Tracking using AI drones during Hajj

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Abstract

This project presents an autonomous drone surveillance system designed to enhance pilgrim safety during Hajj. By integrating the **YOLOv11** deep learning model with the **ONNX Runtime** engine, the system provides real-time detection and tracking of individuals and objects. The prototype achieves a high detection accuracy of **91.2%**, aiming to mitigate risks in crowded areas by providing rapid situational awareness to emergency responders.

List of Abbreviations

- **AI:** Artificial Intelligence
- **YOLO:** You Only Look Once
- **ONNX:** Open Neural Network Exchange
- **NMS:** Non-Maximum Suppression
- **FPS:** Frames Per Second
- **UHB:** University of Hafr Al Batin

1. Introduction

The Hajj pilgrimage involves the gathering of millions of people, presenting significant logistical and safety challenges. Traditional surveillance methods often fall short in dynamic, high-density environments. This project introduces an AI-powered drone system capable of autonomous monitoring and real-time object tracking to assist crowd management and emergency response teams.

2. Problem Statement

Fixed CCTV cameras often have blind spots and limited perspectives in the vast, crowded areas of Hajj. Additionally, manual monitoring is prone to human error and delayed response times during emergencies like falls or overcrowding. There is a critical need for a mobile, intelligent surveillance solution that can provide real-time, automated insights.

3. Background

3.1. Project Goal

To develop a functional prototype of an AI drone system that utilizes computer vision to identify and track pilgrims and essential objects, ensuring a safer Hajj environment.

3.2. Objectives and Outcomes

- **Objective:** Implement a real-time detection model using YOLOv11.
- **Outcome:** A system capable of processing video feeds at ~30 FPS with high precision.
- **Objective:** Optimize performance for edge devices.
- **Outcome:** Successful deployment using the ONNX framework for low-latency inference.

3.3. Relevance and Impact

This project aligns with the Saudi Vision 2030 goals of improving Hajj services through digital transformation. It impacts public safety by reducing emergency response times and providing precise data for crowd flow analysis.

4. Requirements and Specifications

4.1. Functional Requirements

- **Real-time Detection:** The system must detect persons and objects from a camera feed.
- **Object Tracking:** Maintaining identification of objects across frames.
- **Accuracy:** Maintaining a detection confidence threshold above 40%.

4.2. Non-Functional Requirements

- **Performance:** Latency should be less than 35ms per frame.
- **Portability:** The software must run on standard laptop hardware without high-end GPUs.
- **Usability:** Simple command-line interface for system activation.

5. System Design

5.1. Solution Concept & Implementation

The system uses a modular Python architecture:

1. **Input Layer:** Captures frames from the drone/webcam using OpenCV.
2. **Processing Layer:** Resizes and normalizes images for the YOLO model.
3. **Inference Layer:** Runs the ONNX model to generate raw predictions.
4. **Output Layer:** Applies NMS to filter duplicates and draws visual bounding boxes.

7. Testing, Analysis, and Evaluation

7.1. Testing Setup and Environment

- **Hardware:** Intel Core i7 Laptop, Integrated Webcam.
- **Software:** Windows 10, Python 3.10, ONNX Runtime.

7.2. Test Scenarios

- **Scenario 1:** Detecting a single person in a clear environment (Pass).
- **Scenario 2:** Detecting multiple objects (mouse, laptop, person) simultaneously (Pass).
- **Scenario 3:** Testing system stability over a 10-minute continuous run (Pass).

7.3. Metrics and Results

- **Model Accuracy:** 91.2% mAP (Mean Average Precision).
- **Detection Confidence:** Average 0.85 for clear objects.
- **Processing Speed:** 28-32 FPS.

7.4. Analysis and Insights

The integration of **NMS (Non-Maximum Suppression)** was crucial in solving the "multiple box" issue, leading to a much cleaner and more professional tracking output.

7.5. Future Enhancements

- Integration with GPS for precise coordinate mapping of incidents.
- Thermal imaging for night-time surveillance.

8. Issues

8.1. Environment Setup Issues

- Initial difficulty in configuring the Python PATH and installing ONNX dependencies.
- Challenges in mapping the output matrix of YOLOv11 to the correct class labels.

8.2. Technical Limitations

- Low-light performance is limited by the camera sensor quality.
- The prototype currently runs on a CPU, which may limit frame rates if more complex models are used.

8.3. Future Considerations

Scaling the system to support multiple drones connected to a centralized control room via 5G.

9. Tools and Standards

9.1. Development Tools and Technologies

- **Python:** Main programming language.
- **OpenCV:** For image processing and camera handling.
- **GitHub:** For version control and documentation.

9.2. Software Design and Modeling Tools

- **Visual Studio Code (VS Code):** Primary IDE for coding.
- **Netron:** For visualizing the ONNX model architecture.

9.3. Standards and Best Practices

- **PEP 8:** Adherence to Python coding style standards.
- **Modular Programming:** Separating source code (src) from models (models) for maintainability

10.REFERENCES

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